

Project Development Process

ctrlaltcrew — Project Lifecycle Reference

This document explains the typical stages of a ctrlaltcrew project, from first contact to post-launch support. It describes what happens at each stage and what information or decisions are needed from the client to keep the project moving.

Stage 1: Initial Consultation

What Happens

A first conversation (via the AI Project Consultant chatbot, email, or a call) to understand the client's business, the problem they want to solve, and whether ctrlaltcrew is a good fit. This stage is exploratory and does not require a full specification yet.

Information Needed From the Client

- A brief description of the business and the problem or idea
- Rough sense of urgency or desired timeline
- Any existing materials (current website, app, or documents) if relevant

Stage 2: Requirement Gathering

What Happens

The team collects detailed requirements: target users, required features, platform(s), integrations, design preferences, and any technical constraints. For AI projects, this includes identifying source documents or data. See the Project Requirements Guide for the full checklist used at this stage.

Information Needed From the Client

- Answers to the requirements checklist relevant to the project type
- Examples or references of similar products/experiences the client likes
- Access to any existing systems that need to be integrated with

Stage 3: Project Scope Definition

What Happens

Based on the gathered requirements, the team defines a written project scope: what will be built, what is explicitly out of scope, and which package or custom category it falls under. This scope becomes the reference point for the rest of the project.

Information Needed From the Client

- Review and confirmation of the draft scope
- Clarification of any ambiguous or missing requirements the team flags

Stage 4: Estimation

What Happens

The team produces a price estimate and timeline based on the confirmed scope, using the package ranges in the Project Packages and Estimated Pricing document as a baseline and adjusting for the specific features and integrations involved.

Information Needed From the Client

- Confirmation of budget expectations, to align scope with what is financially feasible
- Sign-off on the estimate before development begins

Stage 5: Planning

What Happens

The confirmed project is broken into a development plan with milestones, so the client knows what will be delivered and when. For larger projects, this includes a phased delivery plan (e.g., core features first, secondary features later).

Information Needed From the Client

- Availability for milestone check-ins during the project
- Confirmation of any hard deadlines (e.g., an event or launch date)

Stage 6: UI/UX Design & Architecture

What Happens

For projects with a user interface, wireframes and visual designs are created and reviewed with the client before development starts. For backend-heavy or AI projects, this stage focuses on technical architecture: data models, system design, and integration points.

Information Needed From the Client

- Feedback on wireframes/design mockups
- Brand assets (logo, colors, fonts) if a custom visual identity should be used
- Approval of the final design or architecture before development begins

Stage 7: Development

What Happens

The team builds the application according to the approved scope and design. Development typically proceeds in stages aligned with the milestones set in the planning stage, with internal testing throughout.

Information Needed From the Client

- Timely responses to any clarifying questions that arise during development
- Availability for milestone demos, if scheduled

Stage 8: Testing & Quality Assurance

What Happens

The application is tested for functionality, usability, and (for AI systems) answer quality and relevance. Bugs and issues found during this stage are fixed before the client review stage.

Information Needed From the Client

- For AI/RAG projects: example questions the assistant should be able to answer, to validate retrieval quality
- Any specific edge cases or scenarios the client wants tested

Stage 9: Client Review

What Happens

The client reviews the completed (or milestone) build in a staging environment and provides feedback. Agreed-upon revisions within the original scope are made at this stage before final deployment.

Information Needed From the Client

- Structured feedback on the staged build
- Confirmation of what is considered complete versus what needs adjustment

Stage 10: Deployment

What Happens

The finished application is deployed to production — published to the client's hosting environment, domain, or app stores as applicable. For AI systems, this includes deploying the production knowledge base or embeddings store.

Information Needed From the Client

- Access to production hosting, domain, or app store accounts (or confirmation that ctrlaltcrew should set these up)
- Final go-live approval

Stage 11: Post-Launch Support

What Happens

After launch, an initial warranty period covers fixing any defects related to the delivered scope. Clients can then choose an ongoing support and maintenance plan for updates, enhancements, and (for AI systems) knowledge-base refreshes. Full detail is in the Support and Maintenance document.

Information Needed From the Client

- Decision on whether to continue with an ongoing support plan
- Reporting of any issues found after launch during the warranty period

Process Summary Table

#	Stage	Primary Output
1	Initial Consultation	Fit assessment and next steps
2	Requirement Gathering	Completed requirements checklist
3	Project Scope Definition	Written project scope
4	Estimation	Price estimate and timeline
5	Planning	Milestone plan
6	UI/UX Design & Architecture	Approved design or architecture
7	Development	Working build
8	Testing & Quality Assurance	Tested, bug-fixed build
9	Client Review	Client-approved build
10	Deployment	Live, production application
11	Post-Launch Support	Ongoing stability and updates

Notes on Timeline

The stage-by-stage process above applies within the overall project timeline listed for each package in the Project Packages and Estimated Pricing document. Smaller projects (e.g., a Basic Website) move through these stages quickly and with less formality; larger projects (e.g., a Custom AI/LLM Application) involve more detailed planning and multiple development milestones within the same overall stage structure.